ZANA

Beauty on Your Fingertips

Product & Business Plan

A comprehensive strategy to build Zambia's leading beauty services marketplace
connecting customers with quality salons, barber shops, and independent professionals — including at-home services.

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1. Executive Summary

Zana is a mobile-first marketplace designed to connect customers in Zambia (and later across Africa) with high-quality beauty professionals — salons, barber shops, and independent stylists — many of whom are currently unknown or underutilized. The platform prioritizes convenience, including the ability for professionals to deliver services at the customer's home.

Unlike pure booking software, Zana is a discovery + booking + payments platform. It empowers independent professionals to earn directly, gives lesser-known quality shops visibility, and gives customers an easy, trustworthy way to book services without travelling long distances.

Slogan: Beauty on your fingertips — tap once and get the service you need, at home or at the shop.

Core differentiators: Strong focus on home services, quality discovery of hidden gems, support for independent professionals, and a business model that is fair and scalable for the Zambian market (mobile money first).

2. Vision & Opportunity

The goal is to become the biggest beauty services platform in Zambia and expand across Africa. Many excellent barbers and salon professionals work under someone else or remain unknown. Zana creates an opportunity for them to build their own client base and earn more independently.

Key problems we solve:

- Customers struggle to find trusted, quality barbers and salons beyond the well-known ones.
- Good professionals lack visibility and a simple way to get bookings without relying solely on word-of-mouth or working for someone else.
- Travelling to a salon is inconvenient for many people; home services are desired but hard to arrange reliably.
- No standardized, easy booking and payment experience that works well with mobile money.

Inspiration is drawn from platforms like Fresha (salon booking + marketplace) and the multi-sided efficiency of apps like Yango, but Zana will be purpose-built for beauty services with a strong home-service capability and local payment integration.

3. How Zana Works

Zana is a multi-sided marketplace with three main actors:

1. Customers — Discover professionals or shops nearby (or for home visits), view services, prices, ratings, and availability, then book and pay.

2. Businesses / Professionals — Apply to join, get approved, manage their calendar and services, receive bookings, and track earnings. Includes both fixed shops and independent mobile professionals.

3. Platform Admins — Review applications, moderate content and reviews, manage disputes, control commissions, and view overall analytics.

A customer opens the app, searches for "barber near me" or "home haircut", sees verified professionals with real availability, books a slot, and receives the service. The professional sees the booking in their dashboard, completes the service, and gets paid (minus platform fee). Ratings flow both ways to

maintain quality.

4. User Roles & Applications

Customer App (iOS & Android)

Primary experience for discovery and booking. Clean, visual, and extremely simple. Large cards showing professional photos, ratings, distance, price range, and “Home Service” badge.

Professional / Business App or Dashboard

Professionals can use a dedicated mobile app or a responsive web dashboard. They manage availability, accept bookings, set service prices and durations, view earnings, and communicate with customers. Multi-staff shops can have team calendars.

Admin Panel (Web)

Secure web dashboard for the Zana team. Review new business applications (documents, photos, location), approve or reject, suspend accounts, view platform metrics, adjust fees, and handle support tickets or disputes.

Professionals apply inside the app or via a simple form. Admins review and approve. Once approved, the professional sets up their profile and calendar and can start receiving bookings.

5. Core Features

Customer Features

- Location-based search with map view and filters (service type, price, rating, home service available, distance).
- Real-time availability and instant booking confirmation.
- Detailed professional profiles: photos, bio, services & prices, reviews, portfolio.
- Home service option with clear pricing (base + travel fee if applicable).
- In-app messaging and appointment reminders (push + SMS).
- Secure payments via mobile money (MTN MoMo, Airtel Money) and cards.
- Favorites, rebooking, and booking history.
- Ratings and reviews after service.

Professional Features

- Calendar and availability management (block times, set working hours).
- Service catalog (name, duration, price, home-service eligible).
- Incoming booking notifications with accept/decline options.
- Earnings dashboard and payout history.
- Customer notes and basic CRM.
- Profile and portfolio management.
- For shops: multi-staff scheduling.

- Float / wallet balance view and top-up.

Admin Features

- Application review queue with document viewing.
- User and professional management (approve, suspend, verify).
- Commission and pricing configuration.
- Analytics dashboard (bookings, GMV, active professionals, retention).
- Review and dispute moderation.
- Push notification and announcement tools.

6. Business Model & Monetization

A sustainable model that works for Zambian professionals is critical. We recommend a combination of low fixed costs and usage-based fees so that businesses only pay when they earn.

Recommended Model

• **Commission on bookings:** 10–15% on completed bookings. Lower rate (e.g. 8–10%) for home services to encourage the feature. No commission on the professional's own returning clients if they book via a direct link later (optional incentive).

• **Float / Wallet System:** Professionals maintain a prepaid float (wallet) in the app. The platform commission is deducted from the float after each completed booking. When the float is low, they top up via mobile money. This gives predictability and reduces payment collection risk. Optionally, higher float or premium tiers can unlock higher daily booking limits or better visibility (featured placement).

• **Optional Subscription Tiers:** Basic (free or very low) with standard commission; Pro tier with lower commission, better analytics, and marketing tools. This scales with business size.

• **Future revenue:** Featured listings, in-app promotions, product sales (hair products), and expansion into adjacent services (nails, makeup, spa).

This approach is fairer than high fixed subscriptions for small independent professionals while still generating strong revenue as volume grows. It is similar in spirit to marketplace models but adapted for local payment realities.

7. Onboarding & Trust

Trust is everything, especially for home services. The process should be thorough but not so slow that good professionals abandon it.

• Professionals submit: ID, proof of address or shop location, photos of work/portfolio, service list, and (for home service) a short video or additional verification.

• Admin team reviews within 24–48 hours. Approved professionals get a "Verified" badge.

• Two-way ratings after every completed service. Low-rated professionals are reviewed or suspended.

• For home services: clear address sharing only after booking confirmation, optional in-app tracking, and a clear cancellation policy.

8. Technology Recommendations

To deliver a high-quality, scalable app that can go on both the App Store and Play Store:

• **Mobile:** Flutter or React Native for a single codebase that produces excellent iOS and Android apps with native feel and top-notch UI.

• **Backend:** Node.js (NestJS) or Python (FastAPI) with PostgreSQL for data, Redis for caching and real-time, and cloud hosting (AWS, Google Cloud, or a reliable African cloud provider).

• **Payments:** Integrate local mobile money first (MTN MoMo, Airtel Money) via reliable aggregators (Flutterwave, Paystack, or direct where possible). Card payments as secondary.

• **Maps & Location:** Google Maps Platform or Mapbox.

• **Notifications:** Firebase Cloud Messaging + SMS gateway for reminders.

• **Admin:** Modern web dashboard (React or Next.js).

Start with an MVP that focuses on core booking flow, then add advanced features. Architecture should support multi-country expansion from day one (multi-currency, multi-language later).

9. Go-to-Market Strategy

Classic marketplace chicken-and-egg problem: seed supply first.

• Start in Lusaka. Personally onboard 30–50 quality barbers and salon professionals (both shops and independents) before heavy customer marketing. Offer early-adopter incentives (zero or reduced commission for first 3 months, featured placement).

• Launch customer acquisition with social media (Instagram, TikTok, Facebook), local influencers, and partnerships with universities or workplaces.

• Emphasize home service convenience and discovery of “hidden gem” professionals in marketing.

• Measure success by completed bookings, professional retention, and customer repeat rate.

10. Product Roadmap

Phase 1 – MVP (3–4 months)

Customer app + Professional dashboard + Admin panel. Core booking, profiles, mobile money payments, basic ratings, Lusaka launch.

Phase 2 – Polish & Growth (Months 5–8)

Improved home service logistics, multi-staff support, better analytics for professionals, push notifications, referral program, expand to other major Zambian cities.

Phase 3 – Scale & Expand (Year 2)

Add more service categories (nails, makeup, spa, wellness). Advanced marketing tools for professionals. Prepare for first African expansion markets. Loyalty features and product marketplace.

11. Key Risks & Recommendations

Supply quality: Invest heavily in verification and early manual onboarding. Quality over quantity at the start.

Home service safety: Strong verification, ratings, clear policies, and possibly optional insurance partnership later.

Payment reliability: Test mobile money integrations thoroughly. Have clear refund and dispute processes.

Professional adoption: Make the professional experience extremely simple. Show clear earnings. Offer personal support during onboarding.

Competition: Move fast on local market understanding and home services. Build community and trust that global players may struggle with.

12. Next Steps

1. Validate the business model with 10–15 potential professionals and 20 potential customers (interviews).
2. Define exact MVP feature list and prioritize ruthlessly.
3. Choose technology stack and assemble or hire the development team (or partner with a capable local/remote team).
4. Design the UI/UX with a strong focus on simplicity and visual quality (hire a good designer early).
5. Set up legal structure, payment provider accounts, and basic terms of service.
6. Begin soft onboarding of first professionals while development is underway.

Zana has a clear opportunity to become the go-to beauty platform in Zambia by focusing on discovery of quality professionals, convenience of home services, and fair economics for independent workers. With disciplined execution on supply quality, user experience, and local payments, the platform can scale significantly.

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